

CHAPTER 41 — Jackie

The first thing Zoe wanted to do was reply.

The second thing Elias wanted to do was stop her.

Neither did either.

That was progress.

They sat in the beige estate behind the farm shop with rain ticking against the windscreen and three messages still glowing on the phone between them.

Tell Zoe I did not give them the second route.

They made me give the first one.

My brother and sisters are alive.

Zoe read them again.

Then turned the phone face down.

"It sounds like her."

"Likely."

She let that pass.

Barely.

"I know something they shouldn't."

Elias looked at her.

"Unless they forced it from her."

The satisfaction died before it properly arrived.

"Still better than nothing."

"Yes."

Zoe stared through the rain.

Then remembered two ridiculous words from when they were nine.

“Purple penguin.”

Elias looked at her.

“What?”

“Challenge phrase.”

“And the answer?”

“Green giraffe.”

“That is terrible.”

“That was the point.”

They had invented it after another girl guessed Jackie’s tablet password and read half their messages.

One of them used the challenge.

The other answered with the deliberately wrong response.

Nothing written down.

Nothing sensible enough to guess.

Zoe looked at the phone.

“They might still have forced it from her.”

“Yes.”

“But if she adds something only Jackie would add...”

“Stronger.”

Not certain.

Stronger.

Good enough.

Voss sent one message through the unknown number.

No names.

No questions.

Just:

Purple penguin.

Then they waited.

* * *

Jackie had about ninety seconds.

She knew because the woman who owned the phone usually smoked for two minutes and had already been outside for half of one.

The phone sat on the kitchen counter.

Cheap case.

Cracked corner.

No passcode.

People became careless around children when they had decided the children were powerless.

Jackie had learned that before she was ten.

The house was not locked.

Not visibly.

That would almost have been easier.

There were doors.

Windows.

A small back garden.

A bus stop down the road.

There was also a camera above the front entrance, another covering the rear gate, two adults who changed shifts, and a man who sometimes

arrived with information about three children Jackie had not seen in years.

Prisons did not need bars if leaving made someone else pay.

The phone vibrated.

Jackie glanced down.

Purple penguin.

Her throat closed.

For half a second she was back in Zoe's bedroom.

Nine years old.

Both of them furious that anyone had read their messages.

Purple penguin.

Wrong answer.

Always.

Jackie typed:

Green giraffe. Stop using animal security. It was stupid when we were nine.

She almost added a laughing face.

Didn't.

Too much.

Then:

Do not come here.

Send.

She put the phone back exactly where it had been.

The back door opened.

Jackie was pouring water before the woman came inside smelling of

cigarettes and rain.

"You alright?"

"Thriving."

The woman frowned.

Jackie drank.

"Teenage sarcasm."

"Apparently."

The woman picked up her phone.

Did not look at the screen.

Not yet.

Jackie walked upstairs at normal speed.

Every part of her wanted to run.

She didn't.

The garden gate was easy.

The bus stop was easy.

The road was easy.

Easy and safe were different things.

* * *

The reply reached Voss four minutes later.

He photographed the screen and sent the image through the one-use route.

Vale read over his shoulder.

"That's her."

"Much stronger."

"Much?" "She insulted the security phrase." "That is Jackie." Voss powered the handset down. Vale pointed at the second message. Do not come here. "She knows Zoe." "Yes." "She knows exactly what Zoe will want to do." "Yes." Vale looked at him. "So do you." Voss did not answer.

* * *

Zoe laughed when she read the reply. One sharp sound. It escaped before she could stop it. "Animal security." Elias looked at the message. "That helps." "That is her." He did not correct her this time. The laugh vanished when Zoe reached the next line.

Do not come here.

Of course.

Jackie knew her.

Zoe was already turning the problem into a rescue.

Find the house.

Find Cain.

Find the exits.

Get Jackie out.

The exact kind of plan where Jackie became the thing everybody else moved around.

"What first?" Zoe asked.

Elias looked at her.

Not where are you.

Not who is guarding you.

Not can you escape.

Zoe picked up the phone.

"Her siblings."

“What about them?”

“Are they actually with her?”

That changed what the threat meant.

Voss relayed one question.

Are your brother and sisters physically with you?

Eleven minutes passed.

Then:

No. Separate places. I have seen all 3 live. They can reach them.

Zoe’s fingers tightened around the phone.

“Live?”

Elias waited.

She thought before sending the next question.

If the proof was old, the threat might be bluff.

If it was current—

Current video?

The answer came quickly.

Yes. Youngest lost front tooth last month. Brother has different school bag. Middle sister cut hair. They knew before I did.

Zoe closed her eyes.

Not childhood photographs.

Not information stolen years ago.

Current.

Somebody inside the network had enough access to reach information about all three children.

Maybe through schools.

Placements.

Transport.

Care records.

Maybe through ordinary people who had no idea what their information was being used for.

Cain did not need to own every system around them.

He only needed enough points of contact to make Jackie believe the threat could reach anywhere.

Zoe whispered:

“That’s what they used.”

Elias nodded.

She already knew Jackie had been coerced.

She had known enough for years to understand that whatever happened after the decoy had not been a clean betrayal.

What she had never known was the shape of the weapon.

Now she did.

Three children Jackie had spent half her childhood trying to keep alive.

The real route had never been written down.

They had thought that made it safe.

It had only moved the vulnerability from paper into Jackie.

* * *

Jackie had held out until they showed her the youngest.

That was what she needed Zoe to understand.

Not because she wanted forgiveness.

Zoe had already given her more than Jackie expected simply by asking before acting.

She needed Zoe to understand the mechanism.

The men who took Jackie after the decoy started with questions.

Where was Zoe going?

Who was collecting her?

What time?

Jackie said she did not know.

They knew she was lying.

Then came lights.

No proper sleep.

The same questions until the words became boring enough to lose meaning.

Jackie had grown up with an alcoholic father.

Adults overestimated exhaustion.

You could be tired and still hate them.

Then a man came into the room carrying a tablet.

No raised voice.

No threats.

That was worse.

He played a video.

Her brother leaving a school building.

Current date visible on a screen behind him.

Another.

Her middle sister in a kitchen Jackie had never seen.

Hair cut to her jaw.

Another.

The youngest sitting in the back of a car, laughing at something outside the frame.

One front tooth missing.

Jackie stopped breathing properly.

The man sat opposite her. "You've spent years wanting to know they're alive." Jackie said nothing.

"We can keep them that way."

That was all. No if. No unless. No sentence anyone could later call a threat. Jackie understood perfectly. He asked for Zoe's route again. She gave him the pickup time. The airport. The flight. The arrival terminal. Elias's name. What he looked like. The grandmother address. Everything Zoe had trusted her with. Jackie said it once. Then again because they made her repeat it. She cried after they left. Not because she thought she had made the wrong decision. That would almost have been easier.

She knew what she had done.

She also knew that if they put those three videos in front of her again, she could not promise Zoe a different answer.

They had built the choice so there was only one answer Jackie could live with.

* * *

Zoe's next message was short.

Did they get the airport route before the flight?

Jackie understood immediately.

Timeline.

Not accusation.

She typed:

Yes.

Then stared at the screen.

I am sorry.

Delete.

I chose them.

Delete.

Too simple.

Too cruel to herself.

Finally:

They gave me a choice designed to have one answer. I gave them the airport route.

Send.

She looked at the words.

True. Not clean. True. Footsteps downstairs. Jackie put the phone back where she had found it and walked away. That was the end of the first window. She did not know when another would come.

* * *

Zoe read Jackie's sentence three times. They gave me a choice designed to have one answer. She looked at Elias. "She still says she gave it."

"She did."

"She isn't pretending she didn't."

"No."

Zoe hated how much that mattered. Jackie had not chosen Cain. She had not chosen against Zoe. But she had spoken the route. Coercion did not make the words disappear. It explained why they existed. The distinction felt important. Painful.

Adult in a way Zoe resented.

Another message did not arrive for nearly an hour.

When it did, it came through the same relay but from a different temporary device.

Jackie had found another opening.

After airport failed they kept asking where Elias would take you next. Cottage? Family? Police? I did not know.

Then:

I did not guess.

Then:

Anything they found after that was not from me.

Zoe read the middle line again.

"I did not guess."

Elias nodded.

"That's the second route."

"Yes."

"The airport route was hers."

"Yes."

"What happened after you refused the grandmother address wasn't."

"No."

There.

Finally precise.

Not betrayal.

Not innocence.

Not some cleaner version of the past where Jackie had resisted forever and never spoken.

The truth was messier.

Jackie had given Cain the part she knew because he had reached for the three people she could not abandon.

Then, when Cain wanted more, she refused to manufacture what she did not have.

"She didn't guess," Zoe said again.

"No."

That was enough.

* * *

The anger came immediately afterward.

Hotter than the anger she had felt reading Helen and Brian's file.

Less complicated.

Cain had taken Jackie because she was Zoe's friend.

Then he had used three children Jackie had effectively raised as a lever.

Zoe could see him without having seen the room.

Calm.

Patient.

Tablet on the table.

For the first time in weeks, the answer felt wonderfully simple.

Find Cain.

Tell Elias where.

Let the Reaper finish it.

Zoe looked at him.

He saw something in her face. "What?"

"If we find Cain—"

"No."

She stared. "You didn't let me finish."

"I know where it ends."

"You don't."

"I could kill him."

That stopped her. Elias opened the car door and stepped into the rain. Zoe followed because sitting still suddenly felt impossible. Rain hit her hair and jacket. "He used her siblings."

"Yes."

"He took her."

"Yes."

"He made her give them the route."

"Yes."

"And he's still holding her."

"Yes."

"You could stop him."

"Maybe."

She hated the word. "Maybe?"

"I could kill him."

His voice did not change. "That is not the same thing."

Zoe knew what he meant. She hated him for making her know it. "If Cain dies, Jackie is still inside something."

"Yes."

"And whoever can reach her siblings might not be Cain."

"Yes."

Zoe kicked wet gravel. "I want him dead."

"Okay."

She looked up. "Okay?"

"Yes."

"You're supposed to tell me not to."

"No."

"Why?"

Elias watched her. "Wanting something is not choosing it."

Rain ran down Zoe's face.

She wiped it away.

Hard.

"What do you choose?"

That was worse.

Of course it was.

Zoe looked back at the car.

The phone inside.

The backpack.

The drive.

Somewhere inside it might be enough information to start searching for Jackie's siblings.

Schools.

Placements.

Addresses.

People.

She might find one.

Then another.

Maybe all three.

And then what?

Use them to force Cain to release Jackie?

Prove to Jackie that they could reach them too?

Take the people Jackie loved and turn them into pressure?

No.

The answer arrived before the thought finished.

"No siblings."

Elias waited.

"We don't use them."

"Agreed."

"No searching their addresses. No sending anyone near them. No names in our evidence."

"Yes."

"And no contacting them."

Elias paused.

"Unless Jackie chooses that."

Zoe stopped.

Right.

She had almost done it again.

Not using Jackie's siblings did not give Zoe the right to decide Jackie could never contact them.

"That's hers."

"Yes."

Zoe got back into the car.

She typed:

We will not contact or use your siblings unless you ask. Your choice.

Then handed the phone to Elias.

"That."

He nodded.

Voss relayed it.

* * *

Jackie read the message in the downstairs toilet.

The woman was smoking again.

Jackie was beginning to think nicotine might eventually bring down the entire criminal organisation.

We will not contact or use your siblings unless you ask. Your choice.

Jackie sat on the closed toilet lid.

The words blurred.

She blinked.

Read them again.

Your choice.

Nobody had spoken to her like that about the three of them since she was six.

Adults had decided when the children were removed.

Where they went.

When Jackie could see them.

When she could not.

What information she was allowed.

What information she was not.

Then Cain's people had decided their lives could be turned into a question Jackie had to answer.

Jackie had spent years thinking of herself as responsible for them while possessing almost no real control over anything that happened to them.

Now Zoe had given her a boundary.

Jackie hated it.

That was probably why it mattered. She typed: Do not contact them yet. Please. Then: I need them out of this but not because I traded something else for them. She stared. Sent. Then: Do not come for me. She hesitated. Added: Not yet. That changed it. Good. Zoe would notice.

* * *

She did. "Not yet." "Yes." "She has a plan." "Maybe." Zoe turned. "Maybe?"

Elias looked at her.

"Likely."

"That is practically enthusiasm."

"No."

She ignored him.

The next question was simple.

What do you need?

The answer did not come for nearly an hour.

When it arrived, it was longer.

They think I only know what they showed me. I hear things because people talk around kids. Same legal woman at two places. Some of the same men after moves. They are talking about Westmere and recipients like something has gone wrong. If they know about the phone they will move me.

Then:

If you take me now they close everything.

Then:

Let me stay useful.

Zoe read the last sentence and immediately said:

“No.”

Elias looked at her.

“No what?”

“She does not stay there because she thinks she has to help us.”

“Her choice.”

Zoe glared.

He did not move.

Her choice.

Again.

Infuriating.

Correct.

Jackie had spent half her life being told what she had to do for other people.

Zoe did not get to replace Cain in that equation just because her intentions were better.

But Jackie also did not get to turn herself into everybody’s entire inside operation.

That was the other half.

Zoe typed:

You do not get to be the whole inside plan.

The answer came quickly.

Bossy.

Zoe smiled.

Then another message.

Neither do you.

She laughed.

Actually laughed.

Elias looked at the screen.

"She has a point."

"Do not encourage her."

"She does."

Zoe typed: Nobody gets the whole plan. Including you. Jackie: Fine. Then: I hate it. "That is definitely her," Zoe said. Elias gave her a look. She pointed at him. "Do not ruin it." He didn't.

* * *

Jackie knew enough to be useful. Not enough to become a map. She had been moved several times. Sometimes in darkness. Sometimes with rear windows covered. Sometimes after being told she was simply going somewhere safer. The adults around her were not all the same. Some knew. She could tell from the way they avoided ordinary questions. From the phones taken away. From the instructions whispered outside doors.

From the men who watched exits instead of children.

Others were harder.

One woman had asked if Jackie wanted to speak to her social worker.

Another person immediately said contact was restricted under the case plan.

The woman had accepted that.

Maybe she was part of it.

Maybe she thought Jackie really was a high-risk child under legitimate safeguarding restrictions.

Jackie did not know.

So she did not pretend.

What she did know:

The same legal woman had appeared at two different properties.

Some of the same transport men appeared after moves.

People were frightened about Westmere records.

And about recipient households.

One phrase repeated.

recipient exposure

Another:

Mac has lost his household.

Zoe understood that one.

“Helen and Brian.”

Elias looked at the message.

“Likely.”

She let him have it.

Mac’s control over the family had broken.

The network knew.

Jackie had heard the fracture from inside.

That was useful.

Also dangerous.

* * *

At six ten, Mac learned Jackie had accessed a phone.

Not what she sent.

Not how much.

Only that a device connected with her current property had briefly touched an old contractor route associated with Voss.

The report reached him before Cain.

That was the only reason Jackie was still in the same house.

Mac read it twice.

Then called Margaret Shaw.

"She's alive."

Margaret did not ask who.

"Jackie?"

"Yes."

"Communicating?"

"Possibly."

"With Zoe?"

"Through Voss."

Silence. Mac said: "If Cain learns—"

"He moves her."

"Yes."

"Another property."

"Yes."

"Another vehicle."

"Yes."

"Another chain of instructions."

Mac rubbed his forehead. Every attempt to reduce evidence now produced more of it. Margaret said: "Do you want to protect the girl or the evidence?"

Mac stared at the wall. "That is not the choice."

"It is becoming one."

"No."

"Then what are you protecting?"

Mac did not answer. On the shelf beside him sat an old photograph from a charity dinner. Brian at the edge. Mac beside him.

Both younger. Smiling. Before the favour. Before the route. Before any of it had a name. Margaret said: "Choose before Cain chooses for you." The line went dead. Mac remained seated. He still did not choose. Not yet.

* * *

At seven, Jackie found one last opening. Short. She did not waste it. They will move me when Cain learns about phone. Then: Probably tonight or tomorrow. Then: I can tell you when. I may not know where. Zoe read the messages in silence. There it was. Not a location.

Timing.

Movement.

The first decoy came back to her.

Jackie in Zoe's coat.

A spare backpack.

A false route.

One person outside Zoe carrying the real one in her head.

When Cain captured Jackie, everything Jackie knew became one target.

That had been the weakness.

Not Jackie.

The concentration.

Zoe opened the notebook.

Wrote:

SECOND DECOY

Then stopped.

Elias waited.

"The first one failed because Jackie knew the whole real route."

"Yes."

"And once they had her, they had one person to break."

"Yes."

"This time nobody gets everything."

"Yes." Zoe stopped there.

No assignments yet. No clever diagram. No pretending she had already solved tomorrow. Jackie's next message appeared. Whatever you are thinking, I am not wearing your coat again. Zoe laughed. Actually laughed. For several seconds. Elias looked almost relieved. She typed: It looked better on you. Jackie: Liar. Sleeves were short. Zoe stared at the screen. The first decoy lived between them. So did everything that happened after. The joke did not erase it. Nothing could. But Jackie was here to make the joke. That counted. Zoe looked down at the notebook. Under SECOND DECOY, she wrote one sentence. Jackie is not bait.

Elias read it.

“That stays.”

“Yes.”

She closed the notebook. What came next could wait until morning.

Tonight, it was enough that Jackie was alive.

And this time, nobody was going to build the plan around sacrificing her.